

America's Army: Special Operations v2.0

Entertainment, Shock and Awe...

America's Army (AA) has one thing that FPS fans have lusted over since the time of *Doom*—a good free FPS with multiplayer support. Version 2.0 of AA has six new maps, a customisable M4, a new server browser and two new soldier classes—Special Operations and Indigenous Forces.

Training is made mandatory before you can play online. Though the initial missions are boring, they can be entertaining at times, and you need to upload stats to the game's Web site and get bragging rights for your accomplishments.

The graphics and effects are decent, but nothing extraordinary—just a few impressive dynamic lighting effects. The army has successfully breathed a blend of realism and fun into the game.

The game has authentic weapon noises. Minute details, like the soldier's breath-



The crinkles around his eyes are due to all those years of looking into scopes

ing that affects your aim while sniping, add to the realism. You can even tell if the magazine shells are hitting hard or soft ground.

The necessity to connect to the Internet to complete a training level successfully can be irritating. Patching the game is

no easy feat as some patches are more than 250 MB in size.

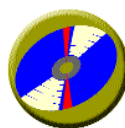
Treasure every flash-bang and frag grenade, and use them wisely. Dynamic lighting and shadows are also implemented quite well. The weapons in the game, though realistic, tend to be too powerful. There's nothing like a good M249 SAW in your hands, firing off several rounds per second.

However, the lack of landmines leaves something to be desired. The distinctive maps provide several ambush points that can be deceiving, so don't be surprised if you find jhonny_243 at an ambush point, waiting for an unsuspecting target.

America's Army 2.0 can be an entertaining romp and is sure to keep you engaged for the next few weeks.

From SKOAR! magazine

Genre: Action ■ **Developer:** U.S. Army ■ **Publisher:** U.S. Army ■ **System requirements:** 733 MHz CPU, 128 MB RAM, video card with 32 MB VRAM, 600 MB disk space, DirectX 9.0 ■ **Price:** Free ■ **Web site:** www.americasarmy.com
Rating: ★★★★★



Star Wars Jedi Knight: Jedi Academy

Cool, riveting, and graphics aplenty

Jedi Academy runs on the *Quake III* engine. Kudos to Raven Software for modifying it, allowing it to generate graphics that none of us thought possible.

You play Jaden Korr, a new student in the *Jedi Academy* on Yavin 4, who's achieved the impossible—building a lightsabre without any formal training.

The game has the normal slew of FPS weapons like rocket launchers, mines, railguns and sniper rifles. The lightsabre has been modified, and you now get three different sabres—the standard Single Blade, the Dual Lightsaber, and the Saber Staff. Force Powers also add to the coolness of the game. Rage, Heal, Lightning and Protect are some of the advanced powers available.



A lightsabre battle in full flow

The graphics are quite nice, while the lightsabre animations are cool. On the flip side, lip-synching in the game is terrible. Weapon sounds lack variety. There is little

change in its soundtrack too.

However, level design is beautiful. The frozen wastelands of Hoth, the burning deserts of Tatooine, and the skyscrapers of Corellia are wonderfully presented. However, *Jedi Academy* is plagued by the fatal disease—Poor AI Syndrome.

One irritating feature is that you cannot save the game after finishing a mission, until you've chosen your new powers and loaded the next level.

Multiplayer gaming in *Jedi Academy* is a nice experience. Force Speed no longer slows down everyone else, but speeds you up instead. All in all, *Jedi Academy* is one heck of a cool game and will keep you riveted for quite a while.

From SKOAR! magazine

Genre: Action ■ **Developer:** Raven Software ■ **Publisher:** LucasArts ■ **System requirements:** 450 MHz CPU, 128 MB RAM, video card with 32 MB VRAM, DirectX 9.0 ■ **Web site:** www.lucasarts.com/products/jediacademy
Rating: ★★★★★